Built to Spill: An Empirical Examination of Executive Functioning and Work-Family Spillover

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Dissertation Proposal Presentation
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Overview

1. Background and Theoretical Framework
2. Work-Family Spillover and Executive Functioning
3. Research Aims and Contributions
4. Hypotheses and Research Questions
5. Method
6. Proposed Analyses

Work and Life in the Modern Workplace

- Boundaries between work and personal life increasingly blurred
- Work-family spillover affects both employee well-being and organizational outcomes
- Managing competing demands requires significant cognitive resources
- ~7% of working adults have some form of (self-reported) cognitive disability:
    - “Because of a physical, mental, or emotional condition, do you have serious difficulty concentrating, remembering, or making decisions?” (cognitive)” (Shockey et al., 2023)

Executive Functioning
[Flesh this slide out with models, pictures, and references]

- Definition: Higher-order cognitive processes that facilitate managing competing demands
- Three core components:
    - Working Memory
    - Cognitive Flexibility
    - Inhibitory Control
- Critical for self-regulation and goal attainment
- Exists on a continuum - varies between individuals

Work-Family Spillover

- Bi-directional transmission of experiences between work and family domains
- Two types:
    - Negative Spillover: Strain and stress impair functioning and role duties in the other domain
    - Positive Spillover: Resources and skills enhance functioning in the other domain
- Requires significant cognitive effort to manage boundaries

An Interdisciplinary Perspective

- Despite prevalence of executive dysfunction (~7% of workforce)
- Minimal integration between:
  - Work-family literature
  - Executive function research
- Limited understanding of how cognitive differences impact boundary management
- Need for interdisciplinary approach

Research Aims

- Examine how executive functioning influences work-family spillover
- Explore moderating factors (gender, social support)
- Broaden theoretical scope by integrating:
    - Cognitive psychology
    - Organizational psychology
    - Sociology

Related Empirical Literature

Include the prior empirical papers here that look at related constructs

- ADHD and Labor Market Outcomes
- ADHD and marital satisfaction
- In the script for this slide, note that these prior papers have examined within-domain outcomes, but never between-domain outcomes

Theoretical and Practical Contributions

- Expands boundary theory by incorporating executive functioning
- Addresses experiences of neurodiverse employees
- Integrates cognitive and social factors in work-family dynamics
- Provides evidence-based guidance for organizational and familial support

Main Effects Hypotheses (H1-H4)
[Include Plots]

- Executive functioning enables better management of work-family boundaries
- Higher EF facilitates resource allocation and role transitions
- Cognitive flexibility helps prevent strain from crossing domains
- Hypotheses:
    - H1: Executive functioning will be negatively related to negative work-to-family spillover
    - H2: Executive functioning will be negatively related to negative family-to-work spillover
    - H3: Executive functioning will be positively related to positive work-to-family spillover
    - H4: Executive functioning will be positively related to positive family-to-work spillover

Gender as a Moderator
[Include Plots]

- Women face disproportionate cognitive load from household management
- "Second shift" and invisible labor
- Hypotheses:
    - H5: Gender moderates the relationship between EF and negative family-to-work spillover
    - H6: Gender moderates the relationship between EF and negative work-to-family spillover
- Research Questions:
    - RQ1-2: How does gender moderate positive spillover?

Social Support as a Moderator
[Include Plots]

- Three types of support examined:
  - Supervisor Support (H7-H8, RQ3-RQ4)
  - Coworker Support (H9-H10, RQ5-RQ6)
  - Spousal Support (H11-H12, RQ7-RQ8)
- Each hypothesized to buffer negative effects of low EF on spillover

Method



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Sample

- Data from MIDUS Study (Waves 2 & 3)
  - Wave 2: n = 4,963 (2004-2006)
  - Wave 3: n = 3,294 (2012-2014)
- Inclusion criteria:
  - Dual-earner couples
  - Currently employed
  - Complete data on all variables

Measures
Include sample items for everything, full scales in appendix]

- Executive Functioning:
    - BTACT composite score
        - Backward Digit Span
        - Category Fluency
        - Number Series
        - 30-SACT
        - Stop & Go Switch Task
- Spillover: Grzywacz scale (4 subscales)
- Support: Supervisor, Coworker, Spousal measures
- Controls: Job demands, family demands, demographics

Proposed Analyses

- Generalized Estimating Equations (GEE)
    - Follow McNeish (2023) and McNeish et al. (2017)
    - Accounts for within-household clustering
        - Alternative models can be used for a robustness check (MLM)
- Models:
    - Main effects (H1-H4)
    - Gender moderation (H5-H6, RQ1-RQ2)
    - Support moderation (H7-H12, RQ3-RQ8)
- 12 models total (4 spillover types × 3 support types)

Expected Contributions

- **Theoretical**: Expands work-family theory to include cognitive factors
- **Practical**: Informs organizational support for employees with executive dysfunction
- **Social**: Addresses workplace inclusion for neurodiverse populations
- **Methodological**: Demonstrates interdisciplinary approach to work-family research

References (Selected key references)

1. Diamond, A. (2013). Executive functions. Annual Review of Psychology
2. Grzywacz, J. G., & Marks, N. F. (2000). Work-family spillover measures
3. Lachman, M. E., et al. (2014). BTACT validation
4. Additional references available upon request



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APPENDIX SLIDES



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Appendix Slide 1

Appendix Slide 2

Appendix Slide 3

Appendix Slide 4

Appendix Slide 5

Appendix Slide 6